

Is Construction Management Safe From AI?

The planning guide — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, the honest trade-offs, and what to ask before you commit.

3.3

AI EXPOSURE · SITE SUPERINTENDENT
where 10 is most at risk

For anyone still choosing — read it straight through.



Before you read this

You're weighing a construction management degree — or a path into the profession — and you want to know what that choice actually looks like in an AI economy. That's the whole job of this guide.

It's written to you directly, whether you are the one choosing or a parent thinking it through alongside them. Where it says "you," a parent can read "them"; it's the same decision from either side.

What this is. A facts document, not a recommendation. It sets out what's known, where the evidence is contested, and where we might be wrong — and then how to choose well given all of it.

If you're the parent, a note on how to use it. Don't lead with the scores. Open a conversation with a risk number and one of two things happens: they shut down, or they get defensive about a choice they're already leaning toward. Read it yourself first, then share it as information you both react to, not a verdict you've reached. They're choosing, not you — the job is to widen what's been considered, not to narrow it.

And one thing specific to construction management. This is the career most consistently overlooked by academically capable students, and it is referenced as the better alternative in three other guides in this index — engineering, architecture and the skilled trades. It scores better than all three at the site end, pays a median above \$106,000, and almost nobody's school careers office mentions it.

If the first reaction to "construction" is a mental image of a building site rather than of someone running a \$200 million project, that reaction is worth examining before the conversation starts.

The short answer

One of the most under-considered good bets available.

A site superintendent scores **3.3** out of 10 — better than licensed engineering at 4.0 and architecture at 5.0. Preconstruction and document coordination scores **7.4**.

Construction management is short of people, protected by physical presence and accountability, and — unusually — has multiple routes in that are getting wider rather than narrower.

It is also the natural destination for someone who likes building things but wants more than a trade — and *which end of it you aim at* is most of the decision in front of you.

The scores

ROLE	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Site superintendent	2.8	3.1	3.3	+0.5	Low
Construction project manager	3.7	4.0	4.2	+0.5	Low– Moderate
Estimator / quantity surveyor	5.5	5.9	6.3	+0.8	Moderate– High
Scheduler / planner	6.1	6.5	7.0	+0.9	High
Preconstruction / document coordination	6.5	7.0	7.4	+0.9	High

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, a service electrician scores 2.5, licensed engineering 4.0, architecture 5.0, and a business analyst 7.6.

Read the table this way: a 4.1-point spread inside a single project. The superintendent standing in the mud and the coordinator managing the document set work on the same job, and one of them is doing work a machine handles well. Choosing the version that keeps you near the site, rather than the document set, is what the rest of this guide is about.

Why site work scores low — the six factors



Here's how a site superintendent answers them. Knowing *why* the site end holds at 3.3 while preconstruction sits at 7.4 is what tells you which version of the career to choose.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

A large share of the office functions surrounding the site, and very little on it.

Scheduling and critical-path optimization. Quantity takeoff and estimating. Document control and RFI management. Progress reporting and dashboards. Compliance and permit tracking. Clash detection and coordination.

What resists: deciding what to do when the ground isn't what the survey said, getting three subcontractors to agree on a sequence, judging whether work is actually acceptable, being responsible when someone gets hurt, and reading a site — what's happening versus what's being reported.

Construction is unusual in that its *information* layer automates readily while its *physical delivery* layer barely moves — and the two sit a few hundred feet apart.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Among the best on-ramps we measure anywhere — and Count the doors, below, explains why the mechanism is unusual.

But "easy to enter" hides a fork worth seeing now. The seat that is easiest to land is often an office one — preconstruction, scheduling, document coordination — which is exactly the 7.4 and 7.0 end furthest into automation. Entering there because a seat is open is not the same as entering the career. The way through is to enter site-based — assistant superintendent, field engineer, a seat where you walk the job — rather than at whichever office rung happens to be hiring fastest. A coordinator desk that's hiring is not the same as a path to the site.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

Substantially. Walking the site, checking work, reading conditions. This cannot be done remotely, and construction sites are among the harder environments for automation.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

Yes, and with real legal weight. Safety accountability attaches to named individuals, and when something goes wrong on a site the consequences are physical.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

Partially. Licensing requirements vary by jurisdiction and project type, and safety responsibilities are statutory — a weaker protection than medicine or law, but real.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

Constantly. Every site is different, every project has a different team, and the problems arrive without warning.

Count the doors

This is the section worth carrying to other careers, because construction management has a form of resilience nothing else in this index has.

Across most of this index, entry-path erosion is bad news. AI absorbs junior tasks, firms hire experience instead of building it, and the on-ramp narrows. Software rates 9.0 here. Junior law rates 9.5. Business rates 7.5.

Construction management rates 2.5, for three reasons.

First, there are multiple genuine routes in, and they compete with each other. A degree in construction management or building science is one. Coming up through a trade and moving into supervision is another, and it remains entirely normal rather than a second-class path. Engineering graduates cross over. Estimators move to site. Very few careers have this many doors — and a field with several routes in is far harder to close off than one with a single funnel.

Second, the entry-level work is physical and therefore not automatable. An assistant superintendent walks the site, checks work, chases subcontractors and learns by being present. That can't be automated the way a junior analyst's spreadsheet work can, so the apprenticeship survives intact — the same mechanism that protects nursing and the trades, arriving here without needing a license to enforce it.

Third, the demand side is genuinely short. The Associated General Contractors' workforce survey found **92% of contractors reporting difficulty filling open positions**, with **80% specifically struggling with salaried roles**, and 45% saying shortages are directly causing project delays. Associated Builders and Contractors estimates the industry needs around **349,000 net new workers in 2026** and 456,000 in 2027.

The general lesson: count the doors. A career with one standard entry route is fragile, because closing that route closes the profession. A career with three or four independent routes is resilient even when one of them narrows.

One honest tension in the demand data

We'd rather flag this than let the shortage figures do more work than they should.

The construction hiring rate hit 3.3% in February 2026 — the lowest on record since the Bureau of Labor Statistics began measuring it in 2000.

That sits awkwardly alongside 92% of contractors reporting difficulty filling positions. Both figures are real, and the reconciliation matters for a student.

What's happening: construction spending growth has slowed, so firms are starting fewer projects and therefore hiring less — while simultaneously being unable to find experienced people for the projects they do have. It is a shortage of *qualified* people in a market that is *hiring cautiously*, which is a different thing from a boom.

Two implications. The skills shortage is structural and demographic, driven by retirements, and it will outlast the cycle. But a graduate entering during a slow-starts period may find the market tighter than the headline shortage figures suggest.

And it reinforces the cyclical caution under what's genuinely hard about it, below. Construction rises and falls with credit conditions and public spending in a way nursing and teaching do not.

What the trend shows

Site superintendent: 2.8 → 3.1 → 3.3. Up 0.5 in three years.

Preconstruction and document coordination: 6.5 → 7.0 → 7.4. Up 0.9.

The gap widened from 3.7 points to 4.1 — the widest internal split of any profession in this index outside translation. Same project, same industry, same building. One end is physically present and accountable; the other produces documents.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Physical / embodied	Strong for site roles	Durable	Construction sites are among the hardest environments for automation — unpredictable by nature.
Judgment under novelty	Strong	Durable	Every site is different, and the problems arrive unannounced.
Human trust / accountability	Strong	Durable	Safety accountability attaches to named individuals.
Regulatory / licensing	Partial	Moderate	Varies by jurisdiction and project type.

The honest read. Construction management's protection is unusually well matched to the threat: the automatable layer is the paperwork, and the paperwork was never the job.

The one thing to watch over a long career is the same as for the trades — **prefabrication**, which moves site work into controlled factory settings where automation performs well. That's covered in the counterargument.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Building the schedule by hand	Interrogating a generated schedule
Quantity takeoff	Reviewing automated takeoff
Chasing RFIs and documents	Largely automated
Producing progress reports	Reading reports that arrive built
Learning the trade sequence by doing the paperwork	Learning it... some other way, unresolved
Walking the site and judging the work	Unchanged
Being responsible when someone gets hurt	Unchanged

One genuinely useful development. BIM and advanced platform fluency is reported to add 10–15% to pay. In a field where the office layer is automating, being the person who can direct those systems and read a site is an unusually strong position.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Reading a site** — what's actually happening versus what's being reported. The least automatable thing in the profession. 2. **Getting people who disagree to agree** — subcontractors, clients, designers, inspectors. Most of the job. 3. **Safety accountability** — being the named person responsible when things go wrong. 4. **Judgment under pressure** — deciding with money running and information missing. 5. **Verification** — knowing when a generated schedule or estimate is confidently wrong.

Notably absent: scheduling software fluency, takeoff speed and document management. These were the traditional markers of a strong graduate and are the fastest-depreciating.

And underneath all five, two traits the score can't grade: **curiosity and adaptability**. The specific tools — the scheduling platform, the estimating package, the BIM environment — will turn over many times across a career. The managers who compound are the ones who stay genuinely curious about how a building actually goes together and re-tool fastest, rather than defending the one way of working they trained on. In a field where the office layer is automating fastest, that flexibility is itself a form of protection — and increasingly it's what firms are hiring for: the trajectory toward running the job, not fluency in this year's software.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The numbers are strong, and they are BLS numbers rather than industry marketing.

- Construction managers projected to grow **9% from 2024 to 2034** — classified "much faster than average" against 3% for all occupations
- Roughly **46,800 openings annually**
- Median annual salary **\$106,980**, with the top 10% above \$176,990
- Sector variation is significant: residential \$91,150, specialty trade \$102,140, commercial \$120,010, heavy civil \$121,060
- Wage growth forecast at 4–6% through 2026, and 6–8% in premium markets

And the specialization premiums are worth knowing early: BIM fluency adds 10–15%; data centers, healthcare, industrial manufacturing and heavy civil all carry higher ranges; certifications like CCM, PMP and OSHA typically add \$5,000–\$15,000.

What people in the field report as rewarding: seeing a project through and standing in front of the finished thing; genuine leadership responsibility early; problem-solving under real constraints; and a clear route to running your own operation.

No graduate degree required, no license exam in most jurisdictions, and progression runs on demonstrated competence rather than credentials.

What's genuinely hard about it

The hours are long and the work is weather-dependent and stressful. A superintendent absorbs pressure from every direction simultaneously — client, designer, subcontractors, inspectors, and their own firm.

It is genuinely cyclical. Construction rises and falls with credit conditions and public spending. A career entered on today's project volume is taking a cyclical bet, and the hiring-rate data under the honest tension in the demand data shows the cycle already turning in places.

Responsibility arrives early and it is real. Safety accountability is not abstract.

And the median is lower than the headlines suggest. Most construction managers are not on \$170,000. The mean is pulled up by large metros and complex infrastructure work; the middle of

the market sits closer to \$105,000.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Construction management tends to suit people who:

- **Are practical and organised** in equal measure — this is the specific combination
- **Are comfortable being responsible** for other people's safety
- **Can hold competing pressures** without becoming rigid or paralysed
- **Would rather be moving than at a desk**
- **Want to see the thing exist afterwards**

It's harder for people who:

- Need **predictable, indoor, nine-to-five** conditions
- Find **conflict draining** — much of the job is negotiating between people who disagree
- Want **creative latitude** — architecture is closer to that
- Need **stability across an economic cycle**

What else is moving this market

The data center buildout is a significant and specific driver. Reporting suggests technology companies could invest upwards of **\$100 billion in US data center construction in 2026 alone**, alongside CHIPS Act megaprojects, healthcare facilities and defense construction.

That is the AI buildout creating construction management demand in the same way it created electrical demand — a career protected from AI that is simultaneously being pulled by it.

Infrastructure funding remains elevated across roads, bridges, water systems and public facilities.

And the demographic case is the durable one. A meaningful share of current demand is project-driven and ends when the builds do. The retirement wave — an ageing workforce leaving faster than replacements arrive — holds regardless of the cycle, and a student should weight the demographics more heavily than the boom.

The AI-native advantage — what to actually do about it

The situation: construction's office layer is automating quickly while its site layer barely moves. That creates a specific and valuable position for someone who can operate in both. A good program should be building this fluency deliberately, not banning the tools or ignoring them.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE CONSTRUCTION MANAGER LOOKS LIKE

- 1. Bridge model and site.** Being the person who can connect what the model says with what the site actually shows. This is the single most valuable position in the profession right now, and the BIM pay premium reflects it.
- 2. Verify.** Knowing when a generated schedule or automated takeoff is wrong — which requires understanding how the work is actually sequenced and built.
- 3. Direct the office layer.** Scheduling, estimating and document control are automating. Being able to run those systems rather than perform them moves someone up the scale.
- 4. Own safety and outcomes.** Everything in this guide points at accountability.
- 5. Specialize deliberately.** Data centers, healthcare, heavy civil and industrial carry premiums and are where the complex work is.

CONCRETE PREPARATION

Before the degree: get site experience however possible — laboring, a trade, a summer with a contractor. Nothing else builds the ability to read a site, and it's the thing that separates a good superintendent from a competent administrator.

During: take the placement, and push for site rather than office. Learn BIM properly rather than superficially — it pays 10–15% and it's the bridge skill.

Entering: aim at site-based roles first even if office work seems more comfortable. The score table says exactly why: 3.3 against 7.4.

The routes in

ROUTE	ASSESSMENT
Construction management degree	The standard route. Look for real site placement.
Trade → supervision	Entirely normal and respected. Arrives with site knowledge no degree teaches.
Engineering degree → construction	Common crossover, particularly civil.
Building science / surveying degrees	Strong technical foundation.
Apprenticeship / degree apprenticeship	Paid, growing, and solves the experience problem directly.
Estimator or office role → site	Possible, though the office roles score worst.

The multiplicity is the point. No single gatekeeper controls entry to this profession, which is precisely why its on-ramp has held while others narrowed.

Where this can lead later

Site management, project management, program and portfolio leadership, preconstruction and estimating leadership, development, owner's representative roles, specialist sector management, and running your own contracting business.

The pattern in this index holds: the further from the site, the higher the exposure. Preconstruction scores 7.4 against site superintendence at 3.3 — and the office roles are the ones that look like promotions. That's worth knowing before accepting one.

What to look for in a program

1. Real site placement — and how much. Office placement is common; genuine site time is rarer and worth more.

2. **Employer relationships that are real.** Named contractors, actual pipelines, honest conversion data.
 3. **Technical depth: BIM, scheduling, estimating, building methods.** Taught as understanding rather than software training.
 4. **First-destination job titles.** Site-based roles or office coordination? The difference is 4.1 points on our scale.
 5. **Safety and construction law content,** which is where the accountability protection lives.
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Questions to ask a program

On placement:

- What proportion of students complete a placement, and how much of it is site-based?
- Which contractors take students, and what's the conversion rate?

On the curriculum:

- How much BIM and construction technology, and taught to what depth?
- How does the program prepare students to verify automated schedules and estimates?
- What changed in the curriculum in the last two years?

On outcomes:

- What job titles do graduates hold at six months — site or office?
- What proportion are with contractors versus consultancies?

Red flags: placement described as "available"; no site exposure; no named employer partners; a curriculum organised around software packages.

The career-hunting checklist

Choosing well is step one. This is what turns a good choice into a good outcome once you're in — worth reading now, because the best time to pick a program is knowing exactly what you'll need to do with it. The first list is for the degree and training years; the second is for the job hunt that follows.

During the degree / training — build toward the site

- **Treat the site, not the office, as the destination.** The protection lives at the site end (site superintendent 3.3, construction project manager 4.2), not in the office roles (scheduler 7.0, preconstruction and document coordination 7.4). Aim every choice at the work that gets walked, not the work that gets filed.
- **Get real site experience before and during the degree.** Laboring, a trade, a summer with a contractor — nothing else builds the ability to read a site, and it's what separates a good superintendent from a competent administrator.
- **Treat the placement as non-negotiable, and push for site over office.** Genuine site time is rarer than office placement and worth more. First-destination job titles are the whole game: site-based or coordination is a 4.1-point difference on our scale.
- **Learn BIM properly, not superficially.** It pays 10–15% and it's the bridge skill — the ability to connect what the model says with what the site shows is the single most valuable position in the profession right now.
- **Get fluent with scheduling and estimating tools as a professional, not a shortcut.** Learn to verify a generated schedule or an automated takeoff — verification is the skill that survives when the office layer automates.
- **Feed curiosity and adaptability on purpose.** The scheduling platform and the estimating package will turn over repeatedly; the manager who re-tools fastest, and stays genuinely curious about how a building goes together, compounds.
- **Keep the frame wide.** Weigh the several routes in — trade to supervision, engineering crossover, apprenticeship — before committing, and remember the order in which you enter them matters. And weight the demographics over the current boom.

During the job hunt — aim for the site, don't just apply

- **Target the protected lanes on purpose.** Assistant superintendent, field engineer, a site-based project role — not "any construction role," which too often points at the 7.4 office rung.
- **Read the title, not just the offer.** Scheduler, planner, preconstruction and document coordination are the automating layer (7.0, 7.4). If you take one, take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
- **Don't grab a role just because it's on offer in an exposed lane.** A role being available doesn't make it safe. A firm still running a large scheduling or document-coordination intake may simply be behind the curve — and that's exactly the rung that gets cut first once it catches up. Availability can be a lagging indicator, not a green light.

- **Prefer the site to the office, even when the office role looks like the promotion.** Preconstruction scores 7.4 against site superintendence at 3.3 — and the office roles are the ones that look like the step up. Proximity to the site someone stands behind is proximity to the protection.
- **Ask the employer where AI is heading in the role.** Whether they're building the job around BIM, model-to-site verification and directing the office layer, or waiting to be forced to, tells you if the seat grows or is quietly being hollowed out.
- **Weigh trajectory over starting salary, and weigh the cycle.** Construction is genuinely cyclical, and the hiring rate is at its lowest recorded level even as the shortage persists — so favor the seat that builds site judgment and BIM fluency over the higher-paid office seat that automates underneath you.

Go deeper — further reading

- **Construction Managers — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — US Bureau of Labor Statistics. The primary source for the 9% growth projection, 46,800 annual openings, and the median and sector-by-sector wage data. Free, and the least commercially interested source available.
- **AGC Workforce Survey** — Associated General Contractors of America. The industry's own annual workforce data, including the 92% figure on difficulty filling positions and the proportion of firms reporting project delays from shortages.
- **Construction management career opportunities** — a useful summary of where demand is concentrated, including the data center buildout and the CHIPS Act megaprojects. Published by a trade-college directory, so read the framing critically; the underlying data is cited to BLS and AGC.

The counterargument — read this one:

The strongest case against our 3.3 isn't robots on site. It's prefabrication.

Modular and offsite construction is growing steadily, and it works precisely by moving work from unpredictable sites into controlled factories — the setting where our own framework says automation performs best. On this reading, the protection erodes not because site work becomes automatable, but because the industry relocates the work somewhere it already is.

Our own scoring concedes the mechanism: in the skilled trades guide, production-line and prefab work scores 5.0 against 2.5 for field service.

There's a second, more immediate challenge too: the construction hiring rate is at its lowest recorded level, which suggests the demand picture is softer than the shortage headlines imply.

Where we land: we hold the score because a superintendent's job is coordination and judgment on a specific site, and that doesn't move to a factory even when components do — someone still has to assemble modules in a real location with real problems. But we'd treat rising offsite construction share as the most important thing to watch in this guide, and we'll report it if it moves.

Bottom line

Construction management is the most consistently overlooked good option in this index — and that's the good news for someone still choosing: the decision in front of you is one almost nobody else is even looking at properly.

It scores better at the site end than engineering, architecture or a business degree. The BLS projects 9% growth and 46,800 annual openings against a median above \$106,000. And it has something almost nothing else here has: multiple independent routes in, which is why its on-ramp held while other professions lost theirs.

The protection is well matched to the threat. What's automating is the scheduling, estimating and document work — the paperwork that surrounds the job rather than the job itself. Reading a site, coordinating people who disagree, and carrying safety accountability are not going anywhere.

The honest costs are real and have nothing to do with technology. Long hours, weather, sustained pressure from every direction, and genuine cyclicalities — with the hiring rate already at its lowest recorded level even as the skills shortage persists.

So the useful advice is: aim at the site rather than the office, because the difference is 4.1 points and the office roles are the ones that look like promotions. Get real site experience before the degree. Learn BIM properly, since it's both the bridge skill and a 10–15% premium. Specialize into data centers, healthcare or heavy civil. And weight the demographics more heavily than the current boom.

And for someone who likes building things and has been told the choice is trades or architecture — this is the third option, it pays better than both at the median, and almost nobody will

mention it.

Questions worth sitting with

Whether you're the one choosing or a parent thinking it through together, these are the conversations that lead to a better decision. Read "you" as whoever the choice is about.

About the work itself

1. What made construction management appealing? Push past "I like building things" to something specific. 2. **Do you want to build, design, or run?** Trades, architecture and construction management are three different answers to the same instinct. 3. Are you comfortable being responsible for other people's safety? That's the defining trait. 4. What does a Tuesday look like in the job you're imagining? What about a Tuesday in February?

Reacting to the findings

5. Site superintendence scores 3.3 and preconstruction 7.4. Does that change which roles you'd aim for? 6. This guide argues that having multiple entry routes is what protects this career. Does that make sense — and can you apply it elsewhere? 7. Was it surprising that this scores better than engineering or architecture?

The harder conversation

8. **Construction is cyclical**, and the hiring rate is currently at its lowest recorded level. What's the plan in a downturn? 9. Long hours, weather, and pressure from every direction. Have you pictured that concretely? 10. The median is around \$106,000, not \$170,000. Is the actual number understood?

Testing it against reality

11. **The most valuable single action:** spend time on an actual site — laboring, work experience, a summer with a contractor. Nothing else builds the ability to read a site. 12. Find a superintendent and a preconstruction manager and ask both what their day looks like. The contrast is the whole guide.

Widening the frame

13. Have you considered coming through a **trade** first? It's a normal route here and arrives with knowledge no degree teaches. 14. What about **civil engineering**? Similar territory, stronger license, slightly higher score. 15. If construction management weren't available, what would you choose? The answer usually reveals what you're actually drawn to.

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For construction management specifically, we've flagged that the sector is genuinely cyclical, that the current hiring rate is at its lowest recorded level despite widely reported shortages, and that prefabrication is the most credible long-term threat to the protection we describe.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Construction Management

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

1. The formula

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Risk} = & 0.35 \times \text{Automatability} \\ & + 0.15 \times \text{EntryErosion} \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Physical}) \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Trust}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Regulatory}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Judgment}) \end{aligned}$$

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-eight careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No license exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent, where being wrong is costly?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

SITE SUPERINTENDENT — 3.3 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.3	5.1	5.5	1.92
Entry-path erosion	15%	2.0	2.2	2.5	0.38
Physical / embodied	15%	8.5	8.5	8.5	0.22
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.5	8.5	8.5	0.22
Regulatory / licensing	10%	6.0	6.0	6.0	0.4
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.5	8.5	8.5	0.15
				Total	3.3 → 3.3

CONSTRUCTION PROJECT MANAGER — 4.2 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.5	6.2	6.7	2.34
Entry-path erosion	15%	2.5	2.8	3.0	0.45
Physical / embodied	15%	7.0	7.0	7.0	0.45
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.0	8.0	8.0	0.3
Regulatory / licensing	10%	5.5	5.5	5.5	0.45
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.0	8.0	8.0	0.2
				Total	4.2 → 4.2

ESTIMATOR / QUANTITY SURVEYOR — 6.3 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.2	7.1	8.1	2.83
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.0	4.5	5.0	0.75
Physical / embodied	15%	2.5	2.5	2.5	1.12
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.0	6.0	6.0	0.6
Regulatory / licensing	10%	4.0	4.0	4.0	0.6
Judgment under novelty	10%	6.0	6.0	6.0	0.4
				Total	6.31 → 6.3

SCHEDULER / PLANNER — 7.0 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.6	7.6	8.8	3.08
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.5	5.0	5.5	0.82
Physical / embodied	15%	2.0	2.0	2.0	1.2
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.0	5.0	5.0	0.75
Regulatory / licensing	10%	3.5	3.5	3.5	0.65
Judgment under novelty	10%	5.0	5.0	5.0	0.5
				Total	7.01 → 7.0

PRECONSTRUCTION / DOCUMENT COORDINATION — 7.4 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.9	8.0	8.9	3.11
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.0	5.6	6.2	0.93
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	4.5	4.5	4.5	0.82
Regulatory / licensing	10%	3.0	3.0	3.0	0.7
Judgment under novelty	10%	4.5	4.5	4.5	0.55
				Total	7.4 → 7.4

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Site superintendent

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	4.3	2.0	1.0	2.8
2025	5.1	2.2	1.0	3.1
Fall 2026	5.5	2.5	1.0	3.3

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.42** and entry-path erosion **+0.07**, for a total of **+0.5** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labor market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.